Wednesday, 12 November 2025

Bishop's Park AGM at The Palace Gardener

1. Apologies

- Alex Laird (FoBP committee)
- Phoebe Shaw Stewart (LBHF Ecology)

2. Minutes of 2024 AGM

• Approved, with one tabled amendment about the incident of the dog in the duck pond area. Luckily the duck did escape unharmed and was later found safely alongside the ducklings.

3. Chair Report

• The Chair thanked the Fulham Palace Gardener for very generously hosting the AGM in their premises
• The Chair thanked the Committee and members of the gardening, litter picking and duckfood volunteer groups for all their hard work through the year
• The Chair also thanked Pauline (Parks Manager) and Ian and his team from ID Verde for all their support for the Park, their ongoing hard work, and for their support of the Friends efforts
• The Chair reiterated the aims of the Friends:
To maintain and improve the Park for all users
    - Ecologically
    - Aesthetically
    - For different age groups and interests
    - For future generations
• The Chair gave a recap of the year:
    • In January the FoBP celebrated 25 years. This was marked by a Summer Drinks Party in collaboration with the Society of Fulham Artists and Potters. Thanks to Natasha for sponsoring drinks and the Teahouse for a delicious cake
    • In March the first Walkabout of the year to highlight issues and opportunities in the Park was held with the Council and IDV. Members are always welcome to attend. The second took place in September
    • In May members of the committee joined the river clean up day held by Fulham Reach Boat Club and afterwards had a taster rowing session
    • Also in May the Friends attended the Fulham Palace Green Meet, commissioning four new bird boxes which have been installed in the Moat Garden

• Duke of Edinburgh Award volunteer Yuvan helped organise a Bin the Butt campaign
• June saw the first installation of new bins throughout the Park which was welcomed as the old bins were in a bad state. Through the first part of the year painting of the river railings was completed, some paths in the Park upgraded, and in the last couple of months the balustrades have undergone significant restoration. The Park has also benefitted from additional planting, splash pool and skate park improvements
• June also saw the launch of the Bishop's Park Tree Trail on the TiCL app, thanks to sponsorship by Fulham Social Hub, a local business network. Point the app at any tree in the Park and find out about it. We now need to publicise this wonderful piece of work so that more people can benefit
• In July Bishop's Park retained its prestigious Green Flag status (flag by the TeaHouse). Vicarage Gardens received a Green Flag for the first time
• Throughout the summer the gardening group met every month to augment the IDV team and keep on top of deadheading, weed control and planting
• Corporate volunteers from Harrods, Irwin Mitchell and Clarion Events also attended sessions through the year and were a fantastic help
• In August the new 'squirrel imperative' FoBP posters went up outside two Park entrances with the headline 'Your Park needs You' and a QR code to get more information or to join FoBP
• FoBP currently has 125 members, with 13 more members than last year and 10 in the pipeline
• In October Simone Turner from the Council Ecology Department ran another fascinating and well attended bat walk
• In November members and volunteers from BP as well as Fulham Palace participated in an illuminating stone masonry class expertly led by PAYE - the company repairing the balustrades. It showed what a complex craft this is. Unfortunately it also reinforced how delicate the heritage terracotta balustrades are
• Over the year the volunteer 'duck food baggers' have filled 3750 bags which sell in the TeaHouse (many thanks for their support) which have raised considerable funds to go towards Park improvements
• The Friends were delighted to win a Civic Award for group contributions to a stronger, safer and kinder neighbourhood

<u>Immediate next priorities are:</u>

- To replant the two beds at the entrance to the Park in Bishop's Ave
- To publicise the TiCLTree App, perhaps to local schools
- To kick off a weekend gardening group (in addition to the weekday group)

4. Committee Election

- Formal thanks was given for the long service and commitment of Roger Weston, who for so many years worked tirelessly to protect and promote the Park
- Committee members were proposed by Mr C Hancock. There being no dissensions Committee Members were elected

5. Biodiversity Report

Stephen Lavery, LBHF Climate Change Champion, and BP nature champion

● In Spring 2024 we sowed a wildflower meadow in the Moat Garden. We saw lots of annuals in Y1 and the perennials have bloomed this year through Spring and Summer
● The council commissioned a SINC (Site of Importance for Nature Conservation) survey in October 24 and we were assigned a grade 1 site of Borough importance (1 level below the highest grading - site of metropolitan importance). This also gave us clear recommendations of how to improve biodiversity which has informed much of our work this year
● In Spring we focused on clearing green alkanet - a non-native and invasive species - from the Moat Garden. This took many days of digging with support from the litter picking and gardening volunteers, as well as IDV and corporate volunteers from Irwin Mitchell. We are now seeing native plants come in and take the space that was cleared
● IDV cleaned out the pond and trimmed back the vegetation which exploded back to life in Spring
● We took part in the Big Butterfly Count 2025, with one survey by the pond resulting in 21 butterflies and 9 different species
● 2 stag beetles were spotted in the moat garden on separate occasions, near stumperies. A sign that the ecosystem is working well
● More recently we took down and cleaned bird boxes in the Moat Garden, removed defective ones and put up 4 brand new ones courtesy of Fulham Palace green woodworkers group
● We have recently scarified an area in the moat garden and sowed more wildflower seeds, with the hope of seeing a second wildflower meadow in Spring 2026
● In the main park near the pond we have designated a small area as a nature conservation area, and will let the grasses grow longer to provide shelter to bugs and insects

<u>What we're doing next</u>
● Planting more pollinator friendly flowers in the Moat Garden as part of the parks improvement project
● Setting aside 1-2 more areas as conservation areas (TBC)
● Another round of alkanet clearing in Spring 2026
● 15m of coir rolls to trial in the pond, in Spring 2026
● Hopefully put in 1-2 more stumperies, as we know they are working well to support insect species

6. Treasurer's Report

2024 was another positive year for income at £3,443, matching 2023. Sales of The History of Bishop's Park book continue albeit at a lower level than 2023. This brought in £144. We continued to sell Victor Ho's beautiful cards at events.
Sales of duck food continued to grow with the support of the TeaHouse and raised more than £1,300 in 2024, and this has continued into 2025.
During the year we contributed to a number of planting projects, which continued into 2025. We closed the year with a surplus of £1,072 bringing our cash position to £12,520

7. AOB

- Questions were raised about the timing and status of the reversal of the FFC compound. Council stated that they hoped around 70% of the compound would be removed by Christmas. Currently the hard core is being removed which partly explains the current noise levels.
- The aim is to remove 100% of the compound by April - it may overrun slightly. More trees than before would be planted and the path would be reinstated
- It was confirmed none of the turnstiles are on Park land.
- If noise is being experienced by local residents the best way to document this is to report it to the Council Noise and Nuisance Team. Residents report noise from alarms and deliveries.
- As there have been issues with noise over the last few weeks, a Noise Abatement Order is already in place
- A financial summary of monies received from FFC for utilising Park space via the compound and projects funded as a result was handed to those present
- Concerns were raised about the possible application from FFC to stage 6 concerts in the summer months
- Council updated that whilst some local Resident Consultation events had been held by FFC, no official application had yet been received by the Council
- FFC would need to undergo the same approval process as any other large event application which entails significant scrutiny
- Residents and Friends' groups are able to put in representations as soon as a planning application has been formally submitted.
- A question was asked about the Skatepark survey and next steps. Council stated that upgrades, based on the survey feedback, were currently being evaluated and will then go to tender. It was noted that different age groups do use the Skatepark, currently amicably
- A new teenage 'chill out' section is being added as a new 'quadrant' in the playground which may help
- Stevenage Park - upgrades may be possible as part of the path upgrade, Council in consultation with FFC
- The meeting closed with thanks expressed by all for the Chair's hard work and contribution throughout the year, which was much appreciated. Thanks were also expressed by the Council for the continued help and support given by the Friends.